

FASTBREAK

High school hoops at a glance.

Boys Top 25

- 1. St. Vincent-St. Mary (4-0): Idle. Next: Today vs. Cincinnati Roger Bacon.
- 2. Shaker Heights (4-0): Defeated No. 5 Lakewood, 65-57. Next: Wednesday at St. Petersburg, Fla.
- 3. Warrensville Heights (7-0): Defeated Parma, 82-46. Next: Friday at Strongsville Tournament.
- 4. Central-Hower (6-0): Defeated Akron East, 79-59. Next: Friday at Hudson.
- 5. Lakewood (5-1): Lost to No. 2 Shaker Hts., 65-57. Next: Friday at Rocky River.
- 6. St. Ignatius (4-1): Lost to No. 24 Euclid, 43-41. Next: Today at No. 10 Cleveland Heights.
- 7. Cleveland Central Catholic (4-4): Defeated Lake Catholic, 93-69. Next: Friday vs. Holy Name.
- 8. Brush (4-2): Lost to Nardonja, 60-56. Next: Friday at Euclid Tournament.
- 9. Buchtel (4-2): Lost to Garfield, 74-62. Next: Friday at Cataract City Classic.
- 10. Cleveland Heights (4-1): Defeated Elyria, 84-66. Next: Today vs. No. 6 St. Ignatius.
- 11. Cleveland East (5-2): Defeated Archbishop Hoban, 61-45. Next: Today at New Philadelphia.
- 12. St. Edward (3-1): Idle. Next: Friday at Strongsville Tournament.
- 13. Glenville (4-1): Idle. Next: Today at No. 17 Orange.
- 14. Mentor (2-2): Defeated Valley Forge, 84-65. Next: Thursday at Westerville Tournament.
- 15. Wadsworth (6-0): Defeated No. 16 Tallmadge, 63-59. Next: Jan. 4 vs. Revere.
- 16. Tallmadge (4-1): Lost to No. 15 Wadsworth, 63-59. Next: Friday vs. Ellet.
- 17. Orange (5-1): Defeated West Geauga, 97-63. Next: Today vs. No. 13 Glenville.
- 18. North Royalton (5-1): Defeated No. 19 Brunswick, 60-53. Next: Friday at North Olmsted.
- 19. Brunswick (4-2): Lost to No. 18 North Royalton, 60-53. Next: Today vs. John Marshall.
- 20. Strongsville (5-1): Defeated North Ridgeville, 77-58. Next: Friday at Strongsville Tournament.
- 21. Medina (4-2): Defeated No. 23 Berea, 66-61. Next: Friday at Maple Heights.
- 22. Olmsted Falls (4-1): Defeated North Olmsted, 65-41. Next: Friday at East Liverpool Tournament.
- 23. Berea (3-3): Lost to No. 21 Medina, 66-61. Next: Saturday vs. Westlake.
- 24. Euclid (3-3): Defeated No. 6 St. Ignatius, 43-41. Next: Today vs. Collinwood.
- 25. Benedictine (2-2): Idle. Next: Today vs. Madison.

Girls Top 25

- 1. Regina (5-1): Idle. Next: Jan. 8 at No. 11 Hoban.
- 2. East Tech (6-0): Idle. Next: Jan. 13 vs. No. 1 Regina at Cleveland State.
- 3. Villa Angela-St. Joseph (5-1): Idle. Next: Jan. 3 vs. No. 10 Shaw.
- 4. Wadsworth (6-0): Idle. Next: Today at Massillon Jackson.
- 5. Elyria (6-0): Idle. Next: Today vs. Cleveland Heights.
- 6. Hudson (5-2): Idle. Next: Thursday vs. No. 10 Shaw.
- 7. Barberton (3-2): Idle. Next: Today at Central-Hower.
- 8. Warrensville Heights (8-0): Idle. Next: Today at Parma.
- 9. Walsh Jesuit (6-1): Idle. Next: Wednesday vs. Admiral King at Strongsville Tournament.
- 10. Shaw (5-1): Idle. Next: Today at Normandy.
- 11. Archbishop Hoban (5-1): Idle. Next: Today vs. Youngstown Rayen.
- 12. Copley (6-0): Idle. Next: Today vs. Wooster.
- 13. Eastlake North (4-2): Idle. Next: Wednesday at Atlanta Tournament.
- 14. Holy Name (4-0): Idle. Next: Today at Cleveland Central Catholic.
- 15. Avon Lake (6-1): Idle. Next: Thursday at Huron.
- 16. Padua (5-2): Idle. Next: Today at Elyria Catholic.
- 17. St. Peter Chanel (3-2): Idle. Next: Today at Lake Catholic.
- 18. John F. Kennedy (6-2): Idle. Next: Thursday vs. Martin L. King.
- 19. Magnificat (6-2): Idle. Next: Thursday vs. North Olmsted at Garfield Heights Tournament.
- 20. Mentor (5-2): Idle. Next: Today at No. 24 Valley Forge.
- 21. Westlake (6-2): Idle. Next: Wednesday vs. St. Joseph.
- 22. Tallmadge (6-2): Idle. Next: Thursday at Tallmadge Tournament.
- 23. Madison (7-1): Defeated Chardon, 81-28. Next: Dec. 29 vs. Westlake.
- 24. Valley Forge (6-2): Idle. Next: Today vs. No. 20 Mentor.
- 25. Vermilion (4-3): Idle. Next: Today vs. Lexington.

The James Journal

A weekly update on the life and times of LeBron James and the nationally ranked St. Vincent-St. Mary boys basketball team:

What's up: The Irish are ranked fourth in the country by USA Today. Today, SVMM takes on unbeaten Cincinnati Roger Bacon at Kent State starting around 8.



James

Redford held James to 16 points. Redford features guard Dion Harris, one of the Midwest's top juniors.

What's ahead: A trip to Camden, Del., for the annual "Slam Dunk to the Beach" holiday tournament. The Irish will play Friday against St. Benedict (N.J.) at 8. If they win, they play Sunday at 5:30 against the Amityville (N.Y.)/Bishop Loughlin (N.Y.) winner.

BOYS BASKETBALL

Bees' third-quarter spurt turns back Braves

MIKE PETICCA
Plain Dealer Reporter

It's not often that 173 seconds of dominating basketball is enough to spark a victory.

It was last night for Medina's Bees. "That was the best segment we've had all season long," Medina coach Jody Peters said of the 15-0 third-quarter run that helped the host Bees to a 66-61 Pioneer Conference boys win over Berea.

"That gave us a glimpse of how we can play. We just need to sustain that. We felt we needed something to get us going."

Guard Matt Shirer scored 22 points and forward Matt Loveless had 16 points and 13 rebounds as Medina improved to 4-2, 3-1 in PC play. Shirer made four steals as the Bees turned a

#21 MEDINA
#23 BEREa

66
61

32-28 halftime deficit into a 43-32 lead with 5:07 left in the third quarter.

"We mixed up our defense a little," Shirer, a 6-0 senior, said. "We trapped their first pass [in the halfcourt man-to-man defense]. Sometimes, we trapped the dribbler over midcourt. Once we get into it, we run and make layups. It really got us going."

Three Shirer steals led to fastbreak layups during the spurt. Twice, he fed backcourt partner Kevin Pap for easy scores.

"They double-teamed, and we panicked and threw the ball away," Braves coach Tom Faska said. "It's simple. Move the ball, and we're fine. But we didn't come to the ball and help our guys

when they were trapped.

"That game was lost in the third quarter. We made a great comeback, but we should have never been in that position."

Peters said Medina's season had been marked by inconsistency. The problem surfaced again as Berea (3-3, 2-2) gradually cut into the Bees' lead and pulled within 59-57 on a 3-point shot by Murray Withrow with 1:28 to go. Medina made 7 of 8 free throws the rest of the way, though.

"We did not finish strong," Peters said. "We were not smart with the basketball and not smart on defense. We were fortunate we made free throws."

Forward Kyle Zimmer led Berea with 14 points, followed by guards Chris Avery (13), Sean Nieman (12) and Will Vazquez (11).

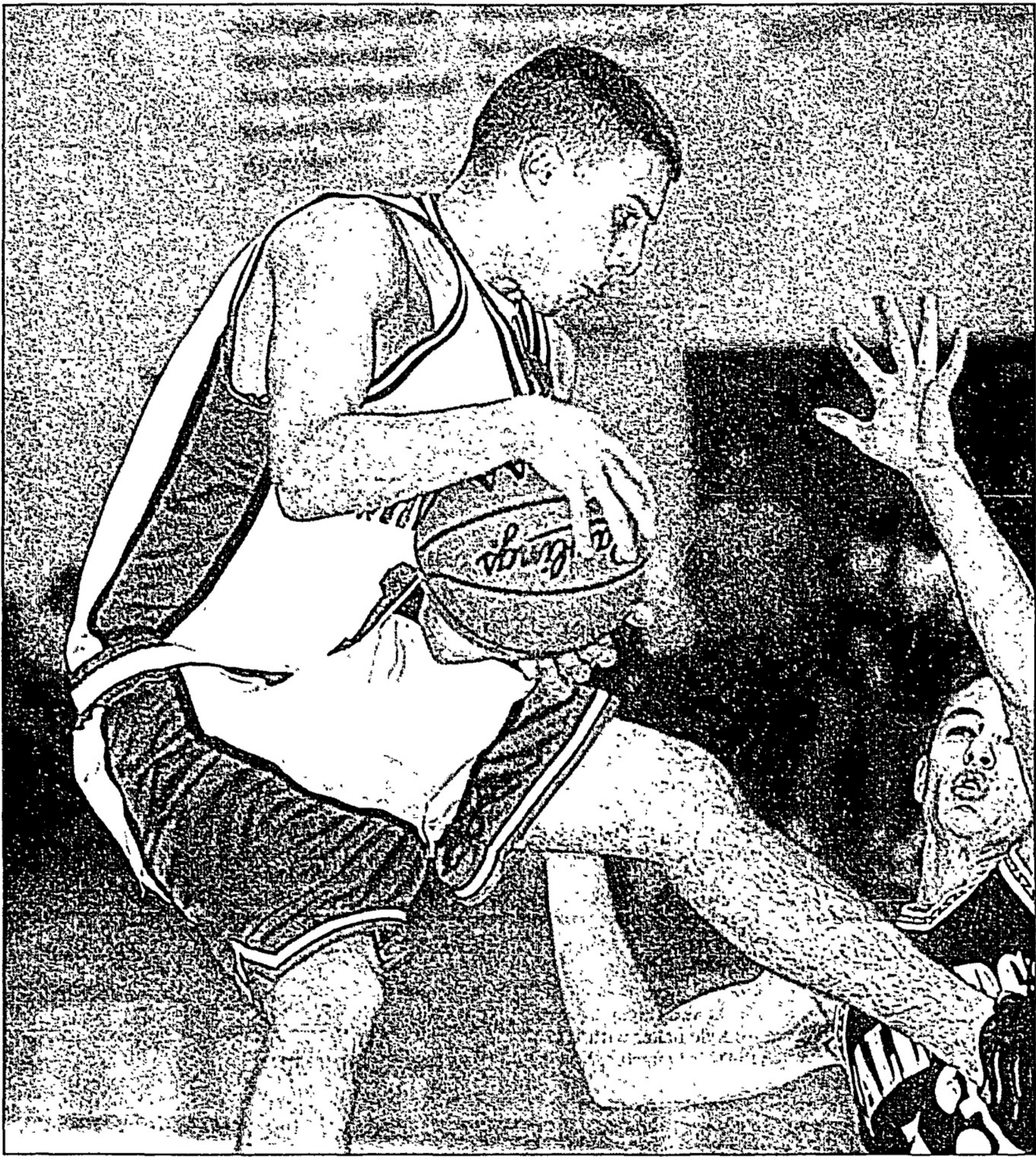
Pap had 12 points and eight assists, helping Medina shoot 52 percent from the field. Amazingly, 24 of the Bees' 25 field goals were shot from within seven feet of the basket. Medina took few outside shots — the only one made was an 18-footer by Dann Bruno midway through the fourth quarter.

"We had an advantage inside," Peters said. "We felt it was paramount for us to get the ball inside. The closer you shoot to the hoop, the higher the percentages are."

The 6-5 Loveless and 6-4 center Ben Chojnacki (seven rebounds) helped Medina outrebound the Braves, 33-19. Chojnacki also contributed six points.

Contact Mike Peticca at:
mpeticca@plained.com, 440-602-4785

BOYS BASKETBALL



BILL KENNEDY / THE PLAIN DEALER

Joe Capatosta soars over Tallmadge's Shaun Rine to catch an inbound pass during Wadsworth's 63-59 victory last night.

Bell can't be stopped as Grizzlies end Blue Devils' 44-game streak

TIM ROGERS
Plain Dealer Reporter

He scored the first points of the game, the last point of the game and a whole bunch in between.

It was all in a night's work for Wadsworth's Doug Bell.

Bell and his teammates remained undefeated and snapped Tallmadge's 44-game regular-season winning streak last night with a 63-59 victory that wasn't assured until the final six seconds.

Bell scored 35 points, had 12 rebounds and two assists as the Grizzlies maintained a share of the Suburban League lead while knocking the Blue Devils out of first place for the first time in more than two years.

"Doug was unstoppable, that's the bottom line," said Wadsworth coach John Martin, whose team improved to 5-0, 3-0 in the league. "Our perimeter guys did a good job of getting him the ball, and he wanted it."

Guard Nick Goddard finished with 12 points, and sophomore Ben Falkenberg made two huge free throws that

gave the Grizzlies a four-point lead with 17.9 seconds to play.

But it was Bell for whom the Grizzlies toiled as they repeatedly got the ball inside, and the 6-7 senior did the rest.

Junior Joe Capatosta had five assists, Goddard and junior Austin Seigneur had three each and Falkenberg had two.

"Bell is a handful, no question," said Tallmadge coach Jon Karnuth, in his first year. "He's the best big man we'll probably see all year."

The first half ended with Tallmadge leading, 28-26, and no one had more than a six-point lead in the final 16 minutes.

"I do what I can for the team," said Bell, who made 13 of 21 shots from the field and 9 of 11 free throws. "Whatever it is. Some nights, it's points and rebounds, and other nights, it's assists and defense. Tonight, it just happened to be points and rebounds."

Senior Brandon Caipen led Tallmadge with 17 points, and guard Alan Bock and center Ryan Ellinwood fin-

ished with 12 points each. But the Blue Devils could not keep up with Bell and junior D.J. Schrock on the boards in the second half, and Bell dominated the fourth quarter by scoring 14 points and getting six rebounds.

Wadsworth had a huge edge at the foul line, where it made 17 of 21 free throws to 5 of 8 for Tallmadge.

Bell, averaging 18.5 points and 11 rebounds, gave the Grizzlies the lead for good at 53-51 when he made a leaning one-hander with 2:30 remaining.

Bock scored on a twisting layup to pull the Blue Devils to within two points with 1:21 to go, but those were their last points until Bock scored again with 18.9 seconds left. Falkenberg extended the lead to 60-56 when he scored his only points of the game on two crucial free throws.

"The good thing is that we get to play them again at our place," said Karnuth. "We will get better between now and then."

Contact Tim Rogers at:
trogers@plained.com, 800-683-7348

Fannin will attend Naval Academy

EDDIE DWYER
Plain Dealer Reporter

Matt Fannin of Lakewood, one of the standout basketball players in Northeast Ohio, has signed with the Naval Academy.

Fannin, who also considered the Air Force Academy, St. Mary's College in California and Columbia, excels in the classroom and on the area's basketball courts and baseball diamonds.

A member of the National Honor So-

ciet, he has a grade-point average of better than 3.7.

A four-year member of the varsity basketball team, the 6-7 Fannin earned All-Lake Erie League, All-Northeast Lakes District and honorable mention All-Ohio honors after averaging more than 18 points, 11 rebounds and three assists last season.

He entered last night's game against Shaker Heights averaging 18 points, 13 rebounds and five assists.

Fannin, who teams with his younger

brother, Mark, on the Rangers' varsity basketball and baseball teams, earned All-Star recognition at this summer's Five Star basketball camp and also received the camp's "Sixth Man Award."

Last spring, his performance as a first baseman-pitcher helped Lakewood to a Division I district final appearance.

Contact Eddie Dwyer at:
edwyer@plained.com, 216-999-4677

BASKETBALL ROUNDP

Williams' last-minute shot stops St. Ignatius

From staff reports

Junior Greg Williams hit a soft lean-in shot with three seconds left last night to give visiting Euclid a 43-41 upset of St. Ignatius in a boys nonconference basketball game.

The Panthers (3-3) entered the game as The Plain Dealer's 24th-ranked team. St. Ignatius, the defending Division I state champion, is ranked sixth. It was the first loss for the Wildcats in 15 games dating to last season.

With 10 seconds left, Williams took the ball from halfcourt on a clear-out play and drove in, connecting from the right side.

St. Ignatius (4-1) had tied the game on a 3-pointer by Mark Barilla with 50 seconds left. The Wildcats later missed the front end of a one-and-one to set up Williams' heroics.

Forward Cyril Ekuibe scored 16 points to lead Euclid. Ryan Stilphen scored 11 for St. Ignatius, and Barilla and Greg Moviel each had 10.

Hawken 74, Grand Valley 47 Funso Lafe went 11-of-17 from the field and finished with 25 points as the Hawks cruised in a battle of Chagrin Valley Conference Valley Division co-leaders. Ben Breisch had 10 points and 10 rebounds for Hawken (6-1, 3-0).

Cleveland Hts. 84, Elyria 66 The Tigers tuned up for tonight's home game against St. Ignatius by routing the visiting Pioneers in a Lake Erie League Lake Division game. Heights, ranked 10th by The Plain Dealer, got 21 points from Alex Nixon and 14 from Jon Battle. The Tigers (4-1, 2-0) held Elyria to seven points in the third quarter.

Bedford 67, Garfield Hts. 65 Junior Roy Malone hit a 3-pointer with two seconds left to help the Bearcats survive a Lake Erie League Erie Division scare at home. Bedford is 3-3, 2-0. The Bearcats got 18 points from Jason Chapman and 16 from Chris Young. Malone finished with 17. John Mills scored 14 for the Bulldogs (4-3, 1-1).

Bay 81, Avon Lake 74 A 42-point night by the Shoremen's Tom Port couldn't stop the host Rockets from scoring their first victory of the season. Port, a 6-7 senior, scored 18 of Avon Lake's 22 points in the fourth quarter. Tyler Trutza and Dan Teichman had 21 and 20 points, respectively, for Bay.

Kenston 74, Mayfield 60 Bob Dubovec scored 20 points and had five assists as the Bombers won at Mayfield to stay unbeaten in the Western Reserve Conference North Division. Matt Phillips had 16 points and Ben Wilson 15 for Kenston (5-1, 3-0). Matt Simek had a team-high nine rebounds off the bench for the Bombers. Brian Nally scored 21 points to go with five assists for the Wildcats (3-3, 0-3).

Nardonja 60, Brush 56 Senior guard Mike Johnson sank 11 of 16 free throws and finished with 23 points as the Knights pulled off a Western Reserve Conference North upset.

Brush (4-2, 2-1) is ranked eighth by The Plain Dealer. Barney Brunsdon (13 points) and Johnson scored 17 of the 26 fourth-quarter points for the Knights. Roy Hall had 21 points and nine rebounds to lead the Arcs. Nardonja is 4-3, 2-1.

Barberton 74, Hudson 61 The Magics won at home to stay unbeaten in the Western Reserve South. Senior guard Kenny Thomas came off the bench to score 27 points for Barberton (5-1, 3-0). Classmate Leonard Mitchell matched him with 27. Explorers standout Phil Bllickensderfer had foul trouble in the first half and finished with nine points.